

Newborn Sleep Survival Guide — Action Checklist

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ESTABLISH THE SHIFT SYSTEM

- ❑ **Establish the Shift System:** Set up a split-night rotation with one partner completely off duty from 7pm to 1am and the other from 1am to 7am, because your brain needs a solid four-hour block of uninterrupted sleep to complete a REM cycle and function the next day.
- ❑ **Establish the Shift System:** Close your bedroom door and wear earmuffs during your off shift, refusing to answer texts or listen for the baby, because the system breaks completely if you remain emotionally available during your recovery time.
- ❑ **Establish the Shift System:** Arrange for a trusted person to take the baby for one two-hour block per week if you're a single parent or lack partner support, because even this small amount of guaranteed uninterrupted sleep prevents total collapse.
- ❑ **Establish the Shift System:** Aim for a minimum four-hour sleep block per parent per night rather than fragmented sleep, because anything less means your brain doesn't do the recovery work and you wake up worse than before you slept.

OPTIMIZE THE SLEEP ENVIRONMENT

- ❑ **Optimize the Sleep Environment:** Set white noise at 70 decibels and run it continuously through all sleep periods, including naps, because this volume reduces the startle reflex and extends sleep cycles without risking hearing damage.
- ❑ **Optimize the Sleep Environment:** Keep the room temperature between 68 and 72 degrees Fahrenheit and check if you're sweating as your guide, because overtemperature causes fragmented sleep and babies wake up hot without knowing why.
- ❑ **Optimize the Sleep Environment:** Pre-prep one or two bottles by pumping in the evening or pre-filling formula bottles before bed, because night feeds become assembly-line fast instead of fumbled five-minute ordeals that fully wake you up.
- ❑ **Optimize the Sleep Environment:** Do a dream feed around 10:30 or 11pm before you go to bed while the baby is in light sleep, because this extends the first long sleep stretch and some babies will sleep from 11pm through to 4am.

RESPECT THE SLEEP TIMELINE

- ☐ **Respect the Sleep Timeline:** Wait until 20 to 30 minutes after your baby falls asleep before attempting to put them down, because this is when they enter their deepest sleep cycle with limp hands, steady breathing, and no eye movement.
 - ☐ **Respect the Sleep Timeline:** Use contact naps strategically when you need to ensure the baby actually sleeps, because research on sleep associations and long-term habits doesn't apply the same way before 12 weeks and fighting contact naps creates more problems.
 - ☐ **Respect the Sleep Timeline:** Recognize that the 0 to 6 week phase is biologically pure chaos with no circadian rhythm development, because knowing this is developmentally normal prevents you from personalizing the sleep struggles and spiraling into frustration.
 - ☐ **Respect the Sleep Timeline:** Track your baby's wake windows and sleep cues to identify their emerging patterns, because understanding the developmental timeline for sleep architecture shifts makes the exhaustion feel temporary rather than permanent.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.